

By and through

Learner workbook

Explain a method or a process without changing the meaning.

Understand the distinction

By often introduces how something is done: by checking the map, by train, by email.

Through can present a route, a channel, or a process: through the park, through an agency, through regular practice.

By + -ing and through + noun are useful starting patterns, not a complete rule. Both words have other uses. Both can introduce a method in some contexts: by working together / through working together. By highlights how; through can highlight the process.

Compare the patterns

METHOD

I saved time by booking online.

Booking is the action that helped.

PROCESS

She gained confidence through practice.

Practice is the process behind the change.

ROUTE

We walked through the station.

Through describes movement from one part to another.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete with an -ing form: I checked the time by ___ at my phone.

2. We found our apartment through an agency. How did the agency help?

3. Is by always followed by an -ing verb? Give a counterexample.

Use it in your own life

Explain one way you learn and one process that has helped you improve.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. looking

By looking explains the method.

2. The agency connected us with the apartment or its owner.

Through identifies the intermediary: someone or an organization that helps connect two sides.

3. No: by train, by email, or by Friday.

The form depends on the meaning and phrase.

One possible response

I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-05.html